Hemming Pants

Shorten pants the way tailors do, minus the tailors. Hand-sewn, no sewing machine required.

What you need:

- Needle and thread that matches the pants (or close enough)
- Sharp pins
- Scissors and a measuring tape or ruler
- Shoes you'll wear with these pants, for the fitting step

Finding the right length

1. Put the pants on with the shoes you actually wear. A hem that's perfect barefoot is often too short with shoes.
2. Roll the pant leg up until it sits where you want the finished hem to be. The classic spot rests just at the top of the shoe.
3. Pin the cuff at that spot, all the way around the leg. Take the pants off carefully and repeat for the other leg.
4. Measure where the pin line sits from the bottom edge, then add one inch for the hem's folded-up fabric. Write the number down against the other leg's number — legs are rarely identical.

Cutting and folding

1. Take the pants off and cut the leg off straight across, just below your mark (keep the extra inch).
2. Fold the raw edge up by a quarter inch and press or finger-press a crease.
3. Fold up again so the total fold is about one inch toward the inside. Pin it in place around the leg.
4. Press this fold with an iron (or flatten it under a book overnight) so the hem holds its shape while you sew.

Sewing the hem

1. Thread a needle with an arm-length of thread, doubled, and knot the end.
2. Hide the first stitch: poke the needle between the folded layers, then bring it out just through the inner fold.
3. Use a slipstitch: catch one or two threads of the pant leg, then poke across into the fold. Pull gently to close the gap. The stitches disappear into the fold.
4. Work your way around the leg, sliding the needle along inside the fold between catches so you need fewer stitches.
5. When you get back to the start, knot off inside the fold and trim close.

6. Repeat on the second leg, measuring against your first note rather than by eye.

Kind tips: If you're nervous about cutting, do the no-cut version: fold the leg up to your pin line and slipstitch the fold in place. The extra fabric stays inside the cuff, harmless and reversible. It's a perfectly good way to hem.